



**YOGIRAJ GAUTAM GIRI**

## OXYGEN IS OPTIONAL

Just his presence could set off a storm—a shaman face on a Shaolin physique—yet the demeanor is calm. Only 32, he wears the aloofness of one honed in Kapal Sadhana, kindling his fire in the iciest Himalayas, living on tea for 12 years ("I love tea, so why not?"). Those were annual yogic expeditions to the outer limits of body and mind. Proof unfolds presently: cessation of breath. Disciples dig a hole. He ties his matted *jata*, and inverts himself into the dark womb of the earth. One minute. Two minutes. Three. By the fifth minute, murmurs of awe rise, then urgent pleas. He relents, brushing off dust, breathing wisdom: "Understand your body, have faith...even you can do what seems impossible."